therefore found it expedient to keep the fleet at a distance of two or three days' sailing. Malinovsky could make no objection. All agreed."[9]

The Presidium decided to lie low and keep the Americans unaware of the presence of nuclear-armed submarines on the approaches to Cuba. The decision proved unavailing. On October 14, the day after the first sighting of the Soviet submarines, a U-2 plane discovered the Soviet ballistic missiles on the island. On October 22, the Soviet submarine captains learned from American radio broadcasts that President Kennedy had announced the imposition of a naval blockade. By that time, the number of Soviet submarines and their approximate locations were already known to the US Navy, and John McCone of the CIA had informed Kennedy and his advisers of the threat presented by the submarines to American ships enforcing the blockade. On the following day the chief of naval operations, Admiral George Anderson, informed McNamara about the formation of a Hunter/Killer group consisting of ships and airplanes whose task was to locate the Soviet submarines.[10]

The members of ExCom discussed the Soviet submarines at their morning meeting on October 24. Their main concern was that the submarines would prevent the US Navy from inspecting Soviet ships crossing the quarantine line. "If this submarine should sink our destroyer, then what is our proposed reply?" Kennedy asked his aides. General Taylor assured him that the submarines would be "covered by our antisubmarine warfare patrols." He also told the president about procedures of signaling submarines to surface. They had been passed to the Soviet side, added Alexis Johnson, who had telegraphed the arrangements to Moscow the previous night. McNamara also described the new procedure that had been developed the previous day. It included the dropping of practice depth charges—a tactic to be used in combination with sonar signals.

Kennedy pushed on with his line of questioning: "If he does not surface or he takes some action … ? At what point are we going to attack him?" He added that he did not want the submarine to be the first Soviet vessel attacked by the US Navy. He preferred a merchant ship. "Well, we won't get to that unless the submarine is really in a position to attack our ship in the course of an intercept," responded General Taylor. McNamara proposed sending "antisubmarine helicopters to harass the submarine." "[The plan,